

THE TEMPTATION OF JESUS ON THE MOUNTAIN:
A PALESTINIAN CHRISTIAN POLEMIC AGAINST AGRIPPA I

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The Temptation Narrative (Mt. 4.1-11; Mk 1.12-13; Lk. 4.1-13) is among the more complex pericopes in the Synoptic Gospels. I shall consider briefly the tradition- and text-historical issues, and argue that the canonical temptation story, which Matthew and Luke derive from Q, represents but one development in a wider tradition, traces of which can be found elsewhere in the Gospels. Of the various temptation stories, that on the mountain top represents the earliest form of the tradition, antedating the threefold temptations and haggadic exegesis of Deuteronomy found in the Q pericope. I shall argue further, developing the hypothesis of G. Theissen,¹ that this story originated during the early 40's CE, and reflects Palestinian Christian polemic against the Herodian king Agrippa I, who unleashed the most severe persecution the primitive church had hitherto experienced. Against this background, the thrust of the temptation can usefully be illuminated.

1. *The Temptation Tradition*

The canonical Temptation Narrative is essentially the literary creation of the evangelists and their sources. The historical temptations of Jesus are reflected in demands to prove himself through demonstrations of

1. *The Gospels in Context* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1992).

power (Mt. 12.38-42 // Lk. 11.16, 29-32; Mt. 16.1-4; Mk 8.11-12; Lk. 11.16; Jn 6.30; *Gos. Thom.* 91.1), and in pressure to allow the popular following generated by his teaching, and more particularly his (feeding) miracles, to escalate into a revolutionary movement (Mk 6.30-45; Jn 2.23-24; 6.1-15, 25-26), and so to acquire popular political leadership. Temptation is reflected perhaps most particularly in the urge to avoid crucifixion (Mt. 16.21-23 // Mk 8.31-33).² Irrespective of how these may be reflected in the Temptation Narrative, this story at the commencement of Jesus' ministry, and the spiritual struggle in Gethsemane at its conclusion (Mt. 26.37-42 // Mk 14.35-40 // Lk. 22.41-44), are the literary creation of church tradition, and are shaped more by Christology and Christian experience than by historical reminiscence.³ The canonical temptations are paradigmatic rather than biographical, and while comparisons with Cynic and Stoic biography are not irrele-

2. J.B. Gibson includes also among the temptations of Jesus occasions when interlocutors sought to entrap him, such as on the questions of taxation and divorce; *The Temptations of Jesus in Early Christianity* (Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1995), p. 17. However, the distinction must be maintained between such encounters and occasions on which Jesus is confronted with the option of using supernatural power or other measures in a manner that would subvert his mission.

3. For discussion, see F.W. Beare, *Matthew* (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1987), pp. 104-106; E. Best, *The Temptation and the Passion* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1965), pp. 28-33; R.E. Brown, 'Incidents that Are Units in the Synoptic Gospels but Dispersed in St. John', *CBQ* 23 (1961), pp. 143-60 (153-55); M.F. Dibelius, *From Tradition to Gospel* (Cambridge: Clarke, 1971), p. 275; J. Dupont, 'L'arrière-fond biblique du récit des tentations de Jésus', *NTS* 3 (1957), pp. 287-304 (299-300); *idem*, *Les tentations de Jésus au désert* (Bruges: De Brouwer, 1968), pp. 97-108; J.A. Fitzmyer, *Luke* (New York: Doubleday, 1981), pp. 509-16; Gibson, *Temptations*, pp. 21-118; D. Hill, *Matthew* (London: Oliphants, 1972), p. 99; J. Jeremias, *New Testament Theology* (London: SCM Press, 1971), pp. 71-75; A. Lindemann, 'Die Versuchungsgeschichte Jesu nach der Logienquelle und das Vaterunser', in D.-A. Koch *et al.* (eds.), *Jesu Rede von Gott und ihre Nachgeschichte im frühen Christentum* (Gütersloh: Gerd Mohn, 1989), pp. 91-100; U. Luz, *Matthew* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1989), p. 184; H. Mahnke, *Die Versuchungsgeschichte im Rahmen der synoptischen Evangelien* (Frankfurt: Peter Lang, 1978); T.W. Manson, *The Sayings of Jesus* (London: SCM Press, 1957), pp. 41-46; I.H. Marshall, *Luke* (Exeter: Paternoster Press, 1978), pp. 167-71; H.W. Montefiore, 'Revolt in the Desert?', *NTS* 8 (1962), pp. 135-41; J.C. Nolland, *Luke* (Waco, TX: Word Books, 1989), p. 177; A. Plummer, *Luke* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1900), p. 105; E. Schweizer, *Matthew* (London: SPCK, 1976), pp. 58-60; Theissen, *Gospels*, pp. 206-21; D. Zeller, 'Die Versuchungen Jesu in der Logienquelle', *TTZ* 89 (1980), pp. 61-73.

vant,⁴ the narrative is concerned more with Christian life and experience.⁵ A complex development of tradition or traditions lies behind the synoptic Temptation Narratives, and the origins of the pericopes lie in the experience of the early church.

Scholars are divided as to the relationship between the allusory reference in Mk 1.12-13 on the one hand and on the other the threefold temptations in the wilderness, in the Temple, and on the mountain top, related in Mt. 4.1-11 and Lk. 4.1-13. While some maintain a single tradition,⁶ others distinguish two sources: the Markan and another preserved in Matthew and Luke. The majority identify the second source as Q,⁷ while a minority argue that the Temptation Narrative belongs to a Matthaean source, and that Luke is dependent on Matthew.⁸ The only possible extant apocryphal parallel is fragment 3 of the *Gospel of the*

4. J.S. Kloppenborg, *The Formation of Q* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1987), pp. 256, 322-24; cf. Dibelius, *Tradition*, pp. 108-109, 275; Manson, *Sayings*, p. 45.

5. R. Bultmann, *History of the Synoptic Tradition* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1963), p. 256; L. Schottroff and W. Stegemann, *Jesus and the Hope of the Poor* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1986), p. 70; C.M. Tuckett, *Q and the History of Early Christianity* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1996), pp. 355-91.

6. T.L. Donaldson, *Jesus on the Mountain* (Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1985), p. 90; B. Gerhardsson, *The Testing of God's Son* (Lund: C.W.K. Gleerup, 1966); Gibson, *Temptations*, pp. 25, 40; J.J. Kilgallen, *Matthew* (Lewiston, NY: Edwin Mellen Press, 1992), p. 31; S. Schulz, *Q: Die Spruchquelle der Evangelisten* (Zürich: Benzinger Verlag, 1972), p. 182; H. Schürmann, *Das Lukas-evangelium* (Freiburg: Herder, 1982), pp. 218-19; W. Wilkens, 'Die Versuchung Jesu nach Matthäus', *NTS* 28 (1982), pp. 479-89 (479).

7. Best, *Temptation*, p. 3; Bultmann, *History*, p. 256; S. Carruth, J.M. Robinson and C. Heil, *Documenta Q: Q 4.1-13,16* (Leuven: Peeters, 1996); Dibelius, *Tradition*, p. 275; Donaldson, *Jesus*, p. 87; Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 507; E. Lohmeyer, *Das Evangelium des Matthäus* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1958), p. 53; P. Hoffmann, 'Die Versuchungsgeschichte in der Logienquelle', *BZ* 13 (1969), pp. 207-23; Luz, *Matthew*, p. 183. Cf. J. Gnlika, *Das Matthäusevangelium* (Zürich: Benzinger Verlag, 1978), p. 83; Marshall, *Luke*, pp. 166-67; P. Pokorný, 'The Temptation Stories and their Intention', *NTS* 20 (1974), pp. 115-27 (126); A. Polag, *Die Christologie der Logienquelle* (Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1977), pp. 30-32; Schulz, *Q*, p. 117; Schweizer, *Matthew*, p. 57; C.M. Tuckett, 'The Temptation Narrative in Q', in F. van Segbroeck (ed.), *The Four Gospels* (Leuven: Peeters, 1992), p. 486. Contra, D. Lührmann, *Die Redaktion der Logienquelle* (Neukirchen: Neukirchener Verlag, 1969), p. 56.

8. H.C.B. Green, *Matthew* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1975), pp. 6, 66. The issue of concern here is not so much this text but the synoptic problem as a whole.

Hebrews, known from the writings of Origen and Jerome.⁹ This makes no reference to temptations, but mentions Jesus having been transported by the Holy Spirit to the top of Mount Tabor. While it may conceivably allude to the Transfiguration tradition (cf. Mt. 17.1-13 // Mk 9.2-13 // Lk. 9.28-36), the majority of scholars maintain that it alludes to the temptations of Jesus.¹⁰ If it can be assumed that the mountain top is a desert place rather than a site of human settlement, then the motifs of transportation by the Spirit and of the high mountain top may suggest a common tradition reflected in Mark and the *Gospel of the Hebrews*. The triple temptation story in Matthew and Luke would represent an embellishment of this common tradition. This could suggest that the three temptation stories in Matthew and Luke had separate origins, as has been widely argued in scholarship.¹¹ The redaction of the tradition in the common source of Matthew and Luke would have included the citations and haggadic exegesis of Deuteronomy, providing an essential unity to the canonical pericope.¹² The *Gospel of the Hebrews* would then represent an independent development in the tradition that diverged at an early date from that preserved in Matthew and Luke.

Matthew and Luke clearly preserve a common tradition. Some caution is required in identifying this with Q, a hypothetical document

9. Origen, *Comm. in Joh.* 2.12; *Hom. in Jer.* 15.4; Jerome, *Comm. in Mic.* 7.6; *Comm. in Isa.* 40.19; *Comm. in Ezek.* 16.13.

10. R. Cameron, *The Other Gospels* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1982), pp. 83-86; Jeremias, *Theology*, p. 71; J.S. Kloppenborg, *Q Parallels* (Sonoma, CA: Polebridge Press, 1988), pp. 18-21; P. Vielhauer and G. Strecker, 'The Gospel of the Hebrews', in W. Schneemelcher and R. McL. Wilson (eds.), *The New Testament Apocrypha*, I (Louisville, KY: Westminster/John Knox Press, 1991), p. 137.

11. Bultmann, *History*, p. 256; Jeremias, *Theology*, p. 71; E. Lohmeyer, 'Die Versuchung Jesus', *ZST* 14 (1937), pp. 619-50; Polag, *Christologie*, p. 146; Schweizer, *Matthew*, pp. 57-58; Theissen, *Gospels*, p. 207. Cf. Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 508; Luz, *Matthew*, p. 183. Contra, Donaldson, *Jesus*, pp. 95-97; Gibson, *Temptations*, pp. 88-100. Gibson argues that the quotations from Deuteronomy are too integral to each of the temptation stories to be secondary, and that the three scenes must therefore have originated as a single tradition. It is also entirely plausible that the citations from Deuteronomy provide a rationale for Jesus' refusal absent from earlier versions, and that the triple temptation story was constructed precisely through redacting specific stories to which the quotations from Deuteronomy could be attached.

12. Cf. W.D. Davies and D.C. Allison, *Matthew*, I (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1991), p. 353; Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 508; Gerhardsson, *Testing*, pp. 11-13.

which would appear, so far as can be established from its use in Matthew and Luke, to have been at least primarily a sayings source.¹³ Strong arguments have, however, been offered for the presence of the Baptism and Temptation Narratives at the commencement of Q, and which account for the presence of these narratives in what is predominantly, but not exclusively, a sayings collection.¹⁴ Much recent Q scholarship would insist that the temptation story is an interpolation or the product of a later redaction of Q.¹⁵ The identification and demarcation of layers of redaction within a reconstructed Q document is a hazardous undertaking, and the place of the Temptation Narrative in the evolution of the Q tradition must remain to some degree uncertain.¹⁶ It would be useful, however, to establish just how early the temptation story may have developed within that tradition, if that is indeed where it originated.

Two principal lines of argument have been proposed for a late date for the Temptation Narrative. One is that the Scripture citations are from the Septuagint, that the text therefore presupposes a Hellenistic environment, which in turn presupposes a late date.¹⁷ The use of the Septuagint, at points where it is very close to the Masoretic text,¹⁸ in itself implies no more than that that text was used when the pericope

13. J.C. Fenton, *Matthew* (London: Penguin Books, 1963), pp. 62-63; Lührmann, *Redaktion*, p. 56; Wilkens, 'Versuchung', p. 479; cf. Beare, *Matthew*, p. 46.

14. Davies and Allison, *Matthew*, I, p. 351; Donaldson, *Jesus*, p. 87; Kloppenborg, *Formation*, pp. 322-24; B.H. Streeter, *The Four Gospels* (London: Macmillan, 1930), p. 291; Theissen, *Gospels*, p. 207; Tuckett, *Q*, pp. 1-82.

15. J.D. Crossan, *The Historical Jesus* (San Francisco: HarperCollins, 1991), pp. 370-71; A.D. Jacobson, *The First Gospel* (Sonoma, CA: Polebridge Press, 1992), pp. 90-92; Kloppenborg, *Formation* 246-48; B.L. Mack, *The Lost Gospel* (San Francisco: HarperCollins, 1993), p. 173; Mahnke, *Versuchungsgeschichte*, pp. 18-19; Polag, *Christologie*, pp. 15, 145-49; Schulz, *Q*, pp. 177-79. Pace, Pokorný, 'Temptation Stories'; Tuckett, *Q*, pp. 1-39, 355-91.

16. N.H. Taylor, 'Interpretation of Scripture as an Indicator of Socio-historical Context', in C.M. Tuckett (ed.), *The Scriptures in the Gospels* (Leuven: Peeters, 1997), pp. 459-67; Tuckett, *Q*, pp. 41-82.

17. A.J. Blasi, 'Role Structures in the early Hellenistic Church', *Sociological Analysis* 47 (1986), pp. 226-48 (228-29); Dupont, *Tentations*, p. 36; Kloppenborg, *Formation*, p. 256; Luz, *Matthew*, pp. 188-89; Mahnke, *Versuchungsgeschichte*, p. 18.

18. Tuckett, 'Temptation Narrative', pp. 483-85, argues that the agreement between transmissions of Deuteronomy at this point is such that it cannot be assumed that it is the Septuagint that is quoted in these verses.

was rendered into Greek.¹⁹ While these are the only citations of the Septuagint in Q, and may imply a unique strand within the Q tradition, they do not necessarily imply any greater remove from the milieu of Jesus and the first Christians.²⁰

A second argument for a late date for the pericope has been the sophistication and the scribal nature of the exegesis of Deuteronomy, in terms of which the occasions in the Pentateuch wilderness narrative when Israel sinned become a type for Jesus' triumph over temptation.²¹ All this implies, however, is that Christianity had at the time of composition attracted or at least engaged with skilled scribes. Paul was in all probability converted by c. 35 CE,²² and Acts 15.5 alludes to Pharisaic converts by the middle of the century. These, even if not themselves scribes, nevertheless suggest the presence of a scribal tradition and scribal influences within the Jerusalem church by the middle of the first century CE.²³ Scribal skills and methods of exegesis could therefore have been present and practised within the primitive Christian communities from a very early date, and the Christian haggadic interpretation of Deuteronomy does not require a date any later than the earliest years of the church. We therefore need to be open to an early date for the Temptation Narrative, as I will argue further below.

2. The Temptation Texts

The Matthaean and Lukan accounts differ in a number of respects. Whereas in Lk. 4.2 it is stated that Jesus experienced temptation

19. Marshall, *Luke*, p. 167; Schürmann, *Lukasevangelium*, p. 219.

20. K.O. Stendahl, *The School of St. Matthew* (Ramsey, IL: Sigler, 1990), pp. 88-89, 148-50.

21. Bultmann, *History*, pp. 254-56; Crossan, *Jesus*, pp. 370-71; Gerhardsson, *Testing*; Jacobson, *First Gospel*, pp. 92-94. Cf. Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 509.

22. For chronological reconstructions, see R. Jewett, *Dating Paul's Life* (London: SCM Press, 1979), pp. 29-30; R. Riesner, *Paul's Early Period* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1998); N.H. Taylor, *Paul, Antioch and Jerusalem* (Sheffield: Sheffield Academic Press, 1992), pp. 51-52. Less plausibly, G. Lüdemann, *Paul: Apostle to the Gentiles* (London: SCM Press, 1979).

23. B. Gerhardsson, *Memory and Manuscript* (Uppsala: ASNU, 1961); Jewett, *Dating*, pp. 63-87; Taylor, *Paul*, pp. 52-56, 97-110. Cf. A.J. Saldarini, *Pharisees, Scribes and Sadducees in Palestinian Society* (Wilmington, DE: Michael Glazier, 1988), pp. 185, 241-76; E.P. Sanders, *Judaism: Practice and Belief 63 BCE-66 CE* (Philadelphia: TPI, 1992), pp. 170-78; Stendahl, *School*, pp. 30-35.

throughout the forty-day period of his wilderness sojourn, in Mt. 4.2 the temptations follow forty days of fasting. Perhaps more conspicuously, the two accounts differ in the order of the temptations. Both begin with the temptation in the wilderness, in which they or their source may be influenced by Mk 1.12-13. Matthew follows with the temptation in the Temple, and concludes with that on the mountain top. Luke, on the other hand, concludes with the temptation in the Temple, and in the middle places that from a high vantage point. A mountain top or similar position is clearly implied, and scholars generally argue that Matthew preserves the original wording, while Luke has purposely omitted any explicit mention of the mountain.²⁴ The most likely reason for this would seem to be the metaphorical nature of the mountain in Q, to which Luke prefers a less physical, but more plausible and no less vivid, image of Jesus' universal vision.²⁵ Good reasons for their respective orders can be discerned in the theology of each evangelist. Luke brings his narrative to a climax in the Temple, reflecting his eschatology and salvation history. Matthew, on the other hand, attributes particular significance to the mountain as a place of revelation, and accordingly climaxes his temptation pericope on the mountain top. A significant majority of scholars believes that Matthew reflects the original order of the threefold temptation story, and that Luke inverted this order.²⁶

24. Beare, *Matthew*, p. 112; Donaldson, *Jesus*, pp. 87-88; Dupont, *Tentations*, pp. 55-56; C.F. Evans, *Luke* (Philadelphia: TPI, 1990), p. 258; Fitzmyer, *Luke*, pp. 507, 515-16; Mahnke, *Versuchungsgeschichte*, p. 127; Marshall, *Luke*, p. 171; Schulz, *Q*, p. 177; Schürmann, *Lukasevangelium*, p. 210.

25. Cf. Donaldson, *Jesus*, p. 88. Cf. the implied heavenly vantage point overlooking the new Jerusalem in Rev. 21.

26. D.R. Catchpole, *The Quest for Q* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1993), pp. 15-16; Davies and Allison, *Matthew*, I, p. 364; Dupont, 'Tentations', p. 290; Fitzmyer, *Luke*, pp. 507-508; Gibson, *Tentations*, p. 83; Green, *Matthew*, p. 66; Hoffmann, 'Versuchungsgeschichte', pp. 208-209; Kloppenborg, *Parallels*, p. 20; Mahnke, *Versuchungsgeschichte*, pp. 176-82; Marshall, *Luke*, pp. 166-67; Nolland, *Luke*, pp. 177-79; Polag, *Fragmenta*, p. 32; Schulz, *Q*, p. 177; Schürmann, *Lukasevangelium*, p. 218; Schweizer, *Matthew*, p. 59; Theissen, *Gospels*, p. 207; Tuckett, *Q*, p. 420; W. Wilkens, 'Die Versuchungsgeschichte, Luk.4,1-13, und die Komposition des Evangeliums', *TZ* 30 (1974), pp. 262-72; Zeller, 'Versuchungen', p. 61. For the opposite position, see Blasi, 'Role Structures', p. 234; Donaldson, *Jesus*, pp. 89-98; Evans, *Luke*, p. 256; W. Grundmann, *Das Evangelium nach Matthäus* (Berlin: Evangelische Verlagsanstalt, 1971), p. 100; Manson, *Sayings*, pp. 42-43.

The temptation on the mountain top stands apart from those in the Temple and in the wilderness in the Q account. Whereas in the Temple and wilderness episodes Satan is portrayed as the equal but opposite interlocutor of Jesus, on the mountain top he appears as a would-be patron able to bestow power on Jesus. As well as his different relative status, Satan assumes a fundamentally different strategy on the mountain top. In the Temple and the wilderness scenes, direct challenges are made to Jesus' divine sonship and exercise thereof,²⁷ with an implied incitement to disobey God through abuse of his power as God's son. On the mountain top, however, the incitement to apostasy is overt, and the challenge to Jesus' divine sonship is implicit in the temptation to obtain power other than from God, as though requiring a mediator with God.²⁸ Furthermore, the Moses typology, in terms of which Jesus is depicted in the temptation on the mountain, is not reflected in the Temple and wilderness scenes, where he is portrayed as the counterpart of Israel during its wilderness period.²⁹ This reinforces the distinctiveness of the mountain pericope.

Whatever essential unity may be ascribed to the Q Temptation Narrative at the redactional level, the distinction in character of the temptation on the mountain and the evidence for parallel traditions in Mark and the *Gospel of the Hebrews* suggest that the threefold temptation

27. This is true irrespective of whether $\epsilon\iota$ is rendered 'if' or 'since'. The issue is not whether or not the devil believes Jesus' divine sonship, but how Jesus uses the power that that status accords him. Cf. Gibson, *Temptations*, pp. 98-100. Gibson denies that the temptation narrative concerns 'false paths' of Jesus' vocation (p. 108), but proceeds to present an interpretation that is at most a variant on this (pp. 108-17). Scholars debate whether or not Jesus' divine sonship is christologically conceived. We do not need to debate the question here. For discussion, see Gerhardsson, *Testing*; R.L. Rohrbaugh, 'Legitimizing Sonship: A Test of Honor. A Social Science Study of Luke 4: 1-30', in P.F. Esler (ed.), *Modelling Early Christianity* (London: Routledge, 1995), pp. 183-97; Tuckett, 'Temptation Narrative'.

28. Davies and Allison, *Matthew*, I, pp. 371-72; Gibson, *Temptations*, pp. 89-90; Jacobson, *Gospel*, p. 90; Kloppenborg, *Formation*, p. 352; Luz, *Matthew*, p. 185; M.E. McVann, 'One of the Prophets: Matthew's Testing as a Rite of Passage', *BTB* 23 (1993), pp. 14-20; Rohrbaugh, 'Legitimizing Sonship'; Schürmann, *Lukasevangelium*, p. 218; G.H.P. Thompson, 'Called—Proved—Obedient: A Study in the Baptism and Temptation Narratives of Matthew and Luke', *JTS* 11 (1960), pp. 1-12 (6).

29. Gerhardsson, *Testing*, pp. 43, 54; Gibson, *Temptations*, pp. 86-87; Thompson, 'Called', p. 6. Cf. D.C. Allison, *The New Moses* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1993), pp. 165-72.

story of Q is not the original. This does not mean that Q necessarily represents a very much later development in the tradition, but simply that there seems to have been a yet more primitive form of the Temptation Narrative. This consisted only of Jesus' being driven by the Spirit, perhaps explicitly to a wilderness, which would not be incompatible with the mountain summit, which is clearly crucial to later developments in the story; the mountain summit is by implication a desert place as there is no mention of an urban fortress, shrine, or any other human occupation of the mountain top. A similar reconstruction of the original temptation tradition has been proposed by Lohmeyer,³⁰ and the remainder of this study will focus on the temptation on the mountain top, and will seek its social, historical and religious context. Theissen has argued that such an inquiry would locate the origins and context of all three Q temptation stories.³¹ The temptations in the wilderness³² and in the Temple,³³ however, will not be considered in further detail on this occasion.

3. *The Temptation on the Mountain*

The mountain top is perceived as a place of divine presence, and therefore a location both of worship and of revelation, in Near Eastern religion.³⁴ In the Hebrew tradition, it is of course closely associated with the Covenant, especially in Exodus–Deuteronomy. The mountain is in apocalyptic thought a location of the Throne of God, as exemplified by *1 En.* 25.3, and a vantage point for receiving revealed knowledge, as in *2 Bar.* 76.3. The symbolism is ambivalent in that the mountain top is associated both with the God of the Hebrews and with pagan deities, as

30. 'Versuchung', p. 622; cf. Jeremias, *Theology*, p. 71.

31. *Gospels*, pp. 206–207.

32. For discussion, see the various commentaries; also Catchpole, *Quest*, p. 15; Dupont, *Tentations*, pp. 13–20; Gerhardsson, *Testing*, pp. 43–44; Hoffmann, 'Versuchung', pp. 214–15; Kloppenborg, *Formation*, p. 251; McVann, 'Prophets'; Rohrbaugh, 'Legitimizing Sonship'; Schottroff and Stegemann, *Jesus*.

33. For discussion, see the commentaries; also Blasi, 'Role Structures', p. 235; Crossan, *Jesus*, pp. 370–71; Gerhardsson, *Testing*, pp. 59–61; Hoffmann, 'Versuchung', pp. 215–16; N.C. Hyldahl, 'Die Versuchung auf der Zinne des Tempels', *ST* 15 (1961), pp. 113–27; Kloppenborg, *Formation*, pp. 252–56; McVann, 'Prophets', pp. 14–20; Rohrbaugh, 'Legitimizing Sonship'.

34. Donaldson, *Jesus*, pp. 9–83; Gerhardsson, *Testing*, p. 69; Lohmeyer, *Matthäusevangelium*, p. 54; J.Z. Smith, *To Take Place* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1987).

befits a situation where a choice is to be made between God and Satan. The ambivalence is resolved in Jesus' repudiation of Satan, and the mountain becomes holy, echoing Sinai and Nebo. For Matthew it foreshadows also Jesus' revelation of the new Law in the Sermon on the Mount, the revelation of Jesus as God's son in the Transfiguration, Golgotha on which Jesus was to be crucified, and the Galilean mountain from which Jesus would deliver his mission charge (Mt. 5.1-7.29; 17.1-9; 27.33; 28.16-20).³⁵

In the Hebrew Bible, Moses is the recipient par excellence of divine revelation (Num. 27.12-14; Deut. 3.23-28; 32.48-52; 34.1-4), and for at least some strands within early Christianity Jesus is the new Moses, and particularly so in Matthew.³⁶ The temptation of Jesus on the mountain accordingly resonates with allusions to the Moses tradition. In an episode reminiscent of Deut. 34.1-4, where Moses on Mount Nebo surveys the Promised Land (cf. Num. 27.12), Jesus is shown all the kingdoms of the world, the scope of the New Covenant (cf. Mt. 28.18-20).³⁷ Developments in the Moses tradition in *Mekhilta* on Exod. 17.14-16 and *Sifre on Deuteronomy* 357 provide further illumination of this text. Moses, on a mountain top, is attacked (verbally) by Satan. During the course of the engagement, Moses surveys the world, cosmic secrets are revealed to him, and he ultimately repels Satan. Abraham is similarly tested by Azazel on Mount Horeb in *Apoc. Abr.* 12-13, and he and the Devil are depicted in dialogue, quoting Scripture at one another, in *b. Sanh.* 89b. The universal vision, accompanied by some form of struggle with Satan, is therefore widely attested in the tradition.

35. For discussion of the significance of the mountain in Matthew, see Allison, *New Moses*; R.L. Cohn, *The Shape of Sacred Space* (Chico, CA: Scholars Press, 1981); Donaldson, *Jesus*; K.C. Hanson, 'Transformed on the Mountain: Ritual Analysis and the Gospel of Matthew', *Semeia* 67 (1995), pp. 147-71.

36. Allison, *New Moses*; Dibelius, *Tradition*, p. 275; Donaldson, *Jesus*, pp. 88-90; Dupont, 'Tentations', p. 287; Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 507; Kilgallen, *Matthew*, p. 34; Manson, *Sayings*, pp. 42-43; Wilkens, 'Versuchung', p. 486. Cf. also Stephen's speech, esp. Acts 7.17-44. For discussion, see M. Hengel, *Between Jesus and Paul* (London: SCM Press, 1983), pp. 20-22; J.J. Kilgallen, *The Stephen Speech* (Rome: Pontifical Biblical Institute Press, 1976); M.H. Scharlemann, *Stephen: A Singular Saint* (Rome: Pontifical Biblical Institute Press, 1968); M. Simon, *St Stephen and the Hellenists in the Primitive Church* (London: Longman, 1958); N.H. Taylor, 'Stephen, the Temple, and early Christian Eschatology' (forthcoming).

37. Dupont, 'Tentations', pp. 296-8; Gerhardsson, *Testing*, pp. 62-66; Green, *Matthew*, p. 69. Cf. 2 Bar. 76.3.

While Mt. 4.8 refers to the kingdoms offered to Jesus as τὰς βασιλείας τοῦ κόσμου, Lk. 4.5 uses the expression τὰς βασιλείας τῆς οἰκουμένης. Whereas κόσμος tends to denote the world in the sense of all creation,³⁸ οἰκουμένη generally refers to the inhabited world, and perhaps more specifically the Roman empire.³⁹ While the distinction should not be over-emphasized, the political nuances of οἰκουμένη may nevertheless be significant. There is a consensus in scholarship that Matthew preserves the original wording of Q at this point, and that Luke has altered the wording, perhaps to emphasize the political connotations of the temptation.⁴⁰ The dominion offered to Jesus is not confined to earthly territories, but transcends the limitations of temporal power, most specifically that of Rome.⁴¹ This anticipates the contrast between the kingdom of heaven and earthly rule in the Beatitudes.⁴²

Another indication of a political overtone is the citation of Torah in the pericope. As noted previously, the quotations from Deuteronomy follow the Septuagint. The only deviations lie in the substitution of προσκυνήσεις for φοβηθήσῃ in the citations of Deut. 6.13 and 10.20 in Mt. 4.10 and Lk. 4.8. In the Septuagint, προσκυνέω is used both for veneration of gods and of human beings of distinction, without necessary overtones of idolatry.⁴³ προσκυνήσεις is used in the prohibition of idolatry in the Decalogue (Exod. 20.5 LXX). The verb occurs repeatedly in the Septuagint of Dan. 3, the account of Nebuchadnezzar's statue, and the refusal of Jewish courtiers to worship it (5, 6, 7, 11, 12, 14, 15 [bis], 18, 28). This would seem to suggest a technical, though not exclusive, usage of προσκυνέω to denote reverence for rulers, in person or through their statues, which Jews would have regarded as idolatrous. While προσκυνέω does not occur in Luke outside the temptation story,

38. Cf. H. Sasse, 'κοσμέω, κόσμος', *TDNT*, III, pp. 867-98.

39. Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 516; Plummer, *Luke*, p. 111; Pokorný, 'Temptation Stories', p. 126; Schürmann, *Lukasevangelium*, p. 211; Theissen, *Gospels*, p. 213; pace, Nolland, *Luke*, p. 180. Cf. also O. Michel, 'οἰκία, οἰκουμένη', *TDNT*, V, pp. 119-59.

40. Davies and Allison, *Matthew*, p. 371; Dupont, *Tentations*, p. 56; Fitzmyer, *Luke*, p. 516; Mahnke, *Versuchungsgeschichte*, p. 128; Marshall, *Luke*, p. 171; Nolland, *Luke*, p. 180; Polag, *Fragmenta*, p. 32; Schulz, *Q*, p. 180; Theissen, *Gospels*, p. 213; Zeller, 'Versuchungen', p. 61.

41. Davies and Allison, *Matthew*, p. 350; pace, Marshall, *Luke*, p. 171.

42. Tuckett, 'Temptation Narrative', pp. 501-506.

43. H. Greeven, 'προσκυνέω', *TDNT*, VI, pp. 758-66.

with the possible exception of a variant reading at 24.52, it occurs frequently in Matthew, with Jesus always the object of worship outside the temptation pericope (2.2, 8, 11; 8.2; 9.18; 14.33; 15.25; 18.26; 20.20; 28.9, 17). Matthew's usage therefore cannot be restricted to any narrow sense, although a clear distinction between legitimate and proper prostration before or worship of Jesus and idolatrous prostration before Satan is clearly presupposed.

Prostration (προσκύνησις) as a symbolic act of homage derived from Persian court ceremonial. The account of Mordecai's refusal to reverence Haman in this fashion, with προσκυνέω occurring three times (Est. 3.2-5 LXX), suggests that at least some Jews regarded the practice as idolatrous. Philo claims that the Jews alone refused prostration, which he describes as βαρβαρικόν, to Caligula, while being somewhat evasive as to whether he and his fellow delegates had been forced to perform the act.⁴⁴ The barbaric, servile and degrading overtones of prostration are emphasized by the contemporary Roman writer Seneca, and similar sentiments are reflected in the later accounts of Caligula's reign by Suetonius, Tacitus and Dio Cassius.⁴⁵ These texts reflect widespread Roman revulsion at the gesture, irrespective of any connotations of deification of the emperor. Although tolerated as an instrument of maintaining political control in the eastern empire, prostration was not practised in Rome until imposed by the self-apotheosizing emperors Gaius Caligula and Nero.⁴⁶ Incense sacrifices to the Roman gods or the

44. *Legat.* 116. Cf. 352: νέοντες εἰς τοῦδαφος ἐδεξιούμεθα. For discussion, see Smallwood, *Legationis*, pp. 209-11, 318.

45. Seneca, *De Benef.* 2.12.1-2; Suetonius, *Gaius Caligula*; *Vitellius* 2; Tacitus, *Ann.* 6.32; Dio 59.27.1, 4-6. For discussion, see A.A. Barrett, *Caligula* (London: Batsford, 1991), p. 151.

46. Barrett, *Caligula*, pp. 150-51; G.W. Bowersock, 'The Imperial Cult: Perception and Persistence', in B.F. Meyer and E.P. Sanders (eds.), *Jewish and Christian Self-Definition*, III (London: SCM Press, 1982), pp. 171-82; A. Brent, *The Imperial Cult and the Development of Church Order* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1999); A. Ferrill, *Caligula* (London: Thames & Hudson, 1991); M.K. Hopkins, *Conquerors and Slaves* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1978), pp. 203-205; F.G.B. Millar, 'The Imperial Cult and the Persecutions', in W. den Boer (ed.), *Le culte des souverains dans l'empire romain* (Geneva: Vandoeuvres), pp. 143-65; *idem*, *The Emperor in the Roman World* (London: Gerald Duckworth, 1977); S.R.F. Price, *Rituals and Power* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984); L.R. Taylor, *The Divinity of the Roman Emperor* (Middletown, CT: American Philological Association, 1931).

genius of the emperor were required of Christians and suspected Christians intermittently from the time of Trajan,⁴⁷ but there is no evidence of official coercion of Jews or Christians to offer worship to the emperor or to Roman gods during an earlier period, except in the case of Caligula's intended sacrilege in the Temple in Jerusalem.

The precise nature of the temptation represented in the pericope is widely debated, but clearly concerns the course of Jesus' ministry, how he was to accomplish his vocation.⁴⁸ It is clear also that God's claim to sole lordship is at issue.⁴⁹ Whether or not messiahship as such is integral to the temptation is a question of definition rather than of substance.⁵⁰ It is clear that any notion of political messiahship is excluded, but only by implication, as Jesus is offered rule over the world, not only over the land of Israel; dominion which he later claims in the closing pericope of the Gospel (28.18).⁵¹ The dominion offered to Jesus exceeds the scope of the aspirations of the various Jewish liberation movements,⁵² and even of the more literate movements that espoused a future Davidic messianic kingdom.⁵³ The temptation concerns not the old but the new covenant, that through which Jesus would redeem the idolatrous legacy of Israel, not realize its political aspirations.⁵⁴

47. Pliny, *Ep.* 10.96; *Mart. Pol.* 4; 8.2; 9.2; 10.1. Cf. Brent, *Cult.* pp. 4-7. For an account of measures taken against the Jewish population of Antioch on the Orontes in 70 CE, according to Josephus, see *War* 7.3.3 §51.

48. Beare, *Matthew*, p. 112; F.V. Filson, *Matthew* (London: A. & C. Black, 1971), p. 70; Nolland, *Luke*, p. 179.

49. Schottroff and Stegemann, *Jesus*, pp. 53-54.

50. Donaldson, *Jesus*, pp. 90-92; Hill, *Matthew*, p. 102; Hoffmann, 'Versuchung', pp. 213-14; Manson, *Sayings*, p. 45; Nolland, *Luke*, p. 179; Pokorný, 'Temptation Stories', pp. 122-25; Schottroff and Stegemann, *Jesus*, pp. 54-56; Schulz, *Q*, p. 187. Cf. also Lohmeyer, 'Versuchung', p. 631; Marshall, *Luke*, p. 172; Schürmann, *Lukasevangelium*, pp. 212-18; Tuckett, 'Temptation Narrative'.

51. Gnlika, *Matthäusevangelium*, p. 90; Kloppenborg, *Formation*, p. 256; Luz, *Matthew*, p. 185; Schweizer, *Matthew*, p. 60. Cf. Marshall, *Luke*, p. 172. For discussion of the nature of messiahship, see articles in J.H. Charlesworth (ed.), *The Messiah* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1992).

52. See R.A. Horsley and J.S. Hanson, *Bandits, Prophets, and Messiahs* (San Francisco: Harper, 1988).

53. E.g. *Pss. Sol.* 17.

54. Green, *Matthew*, p. 67; C.H. Talbert, *Reading Luke* (London: SPCK, 1982), p. 47; Thompson, 'Called', p. 5. Cf. Dupont, *Tentations*, pp. 24-27; Fenton, *Matthew*, p. 62; Gerhardsson, *Testing*, pp. 11-13.

4. Agrippa: The Political Background

Theissen has argued that the Temptation Narrative, and in particular the episode on the mountain top, reflects the reign of Caligula (37–41 CE).⁵⁵ The Jewish people in Palestine had been confronted with the prospect of idolatrous worship of the emperor in 40 CE, when Caligula decreed that his statue be erected in the Temple in Jerusalem.⁵⁶ The motif of prostration before an apotheosized earthly ruler with the power and the disposition to bestow kingdoms clearly reflects a Roman emperor, and none better than Caligula. Theissen accordingly argues that Caligula serves as the model for Satan in this pericope, and that the tradition was formulated in c. 40 CE.

I wish to argue that the story of the temptation of Jesus on the mountain top is a polemic not so much against Caligula as against the Herodian client king Agrippa I, who had obtained much of his power and territory through indulgence of the self-apotheosizing emperor. The temptation with which Jesus is confronted in Mt. 4.8 // Lk. 4.5 is precisely to obtain earthly dominion through homage to Satan. Theissen has correctly identified Caligula as the model for Satan. However, as noted above, Satan does not engage Jesus as an equal dialogue partner in this episode, but as a prospective patron. The antitype of Jesus is therefore not Satan, but the one who, unlike Jesus, accepts Satan's patronage and the power and territory that is the reward of homage to Satan. This role, I would argue, is filled, from a Palestinian Christian point of view, by Agrippa I. He appears in Acts, under the family name Herod, as a persecutor of the Jerusalem church, and dies subsequently as a consequence of accepting idolatrous worship (Acts 12.1–4, 20–23).⁵⁷ While the situation precipitated by Caligula lies in the background, it is specifically the actions of Agrippa that are alluded to in the temptation on the mountain top.

55. *Gospels*, pp. 206–21.

56. Josephus, *War* 2.10.1–14.3 §§184–283; *Ant.* 18.7.2–8.9 §§256–309; Philo, *Leg.* 30–42 §§197–337. For discussion, see N.H. Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity and the Caligula Crisis: 1. Social and Historical Reconstruction', *JSNT* 61 (1996), pp. 101–24; *idem*, 'Popular Opposition to Caligula in Jewish Palestine', *JSJ* 32 (2001), pp. 54–70.

57. Cf. Josephus, *Ant.* 19.8.2 §§343–52. For discussion of the two accounts, see D.R. Schwartz, *Agrippa I* (Tübingen: J.C.B. Mohr, 1990), pp. 145–49. Cf. also the account of the death of the Seleucid Antiochus IV Epiphanes, 1 Macc. 2.62.

Caligula is the one who has dominion over πάσας τὰς βασιλείας τῆς οἰκουμένης (Lk. 4.5), and bestows power on client kings. In 37 CE, Agrippa received from Caligula Gaulanitis, Trachonitis, Batanea and Panaeas, the former tetrarchy of Herod Philip, and Abila, the former territory of Lysanias.⁵⁸ He received also the title REX SOCIUSQUE ET AMICUS.⁵⁹ Agrippa was the first of six client kings created by Caligula,⁶⁰ and the first ever to receive the ORNAMENTA PRAETORIA.⁶¹ While Dio's account of the investiture of the client kings makes no explicit reference to prostration before Caligula, there must be some likelihood that Agrippa and the other client kings acknowledged the emperor's supremacy in this or some similar fashion.⁶² Any such action would at the very least have been open to interpretation as acquiescing in Caligula's claims to divine status, and not necessarily only by Jews.⁶³ Any profession of Jewish monotheism on Agrippa's part⁶⁴ would have been compromised by the coronation ceremony, especially if this took place in the temple of Jupiter Capitolinus.⁶⁵ There is, furthermore, inscriptional evidence that client kings were viewed as members of a pantheon surrounding Caligula.⁶⁶ However unremarkable and lacking in theological meaning such gestures and terminology may have been to the majority of the inhabitants of the Roman empire, they would nevertheless have scandalized any Jews who expected Agrippa to be Torah observant.

58. Josephus, *Ant.* 18.6.10 §§236-37; Dio, *Hist.* 59.12.2.

59. Cf. E. Schürer *et al.*, *The History of the Jewish People in the Age of Jesus Christ (175 B.C.–A.D. 135)*, I (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1973), p. 351; D. Wardle, 'Caligula and the Client Kings', *CIQ* 42 (1992), pp. 437-43.

60. Dio, *Hist.* 59.12.2.

61. Cf. Philo, *Flacc.* 6 §40.

62. *Hist.* 59.12.2. Cf. Theissen, *Gospels*, pp. 214-15.

63. Cf. Suetonius, *Vitellius* 2.

64. That Agrippa was not an observant Jew is now generally recognized in scholarship; cf. Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 131-33. The rabbinic texts in which his name appears (*m. Sot.* 7.8; *m. Bikk.* 3.4; *t. Pes.* 4; *t. Sot.* 7.16; *y. Ber.* 7.2; *y. Šeq.* 5.2; *y. Naz.* 5.5; *b. Pes.* 64b, 107b; *b. Yom.* 20b; *b. Suk.* 27a; *b. Ket.* 17a; *b. Sot.* 41b) do not specify which Agrippa is alluded to, or whether the name is used simply to designate a royal figure. Furthermore, these texts do not unequivocally reflect consistent Torah observance. For discussion, see Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 159-68.

65. Schwartz, *Agrippa*, p. 131, cites numismatic evidence, which not merely suggests this location, but may depict a pig sacrifice on this occasion.

66. *IGR* IV.145: εἰς συναρχίαν τελικοῦτων θεῶν.

Agrippa's fortunes progressed beyond his initial elevation to kingship when, having incited Caligula against his uncle, brother-in-law and former benefactor Antipas, tetrarch of Galilee and Peraea, Agrippa received from the emperor his territory also, in 39 CE.⁶⁷ The same year, Agrippa named his daughter Drusilla after Caligula's recently deceased and deified sister and alleged concubine.⁶⁸ According to Dio Cassius, Agrippa influenced Caligula's style of rule away from traditional Roman patterns of governance in the direction of oriental despotism, for which Dio labels him τυραννοδιδάσκαλος.⁶⁹ This included not only arbitrary and unrestrained use of power, but presumably also other trappings of oriental monarchy, including sacral kingship and divine ruler cults.

Caligula's assassination and the accession of Claudius, in which Agrippa, according to Josephus, acted as a significant power broker,⁷⁰ defused the threat to the Temple. Claudius confirmed Agrippa in his territories, and added to them Judaea, Samaria and Idumaea, together with jurisdiction over the Temple and the right of nomination to the high priesthood.⁷¹ At the same time, the Senate bestowed consular rank

67. Josephus, *Ant.* 18.7.1-2 §§240-55; *War* 2.9.6 §§181-83. Philo's description of Agrippa as king of Judaea, in his account of his visit to Alexandria in 38 CE (*Flacc.* 2 §6), is anachronistic.

68. Suetonius, *Gaius Caligula* 24. S.H. Perowne, *The Later Herods* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1965), p. 59. L.L. Grabbe, *Judaism from Cyrus to Hadrian* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1992), p. 430, asserts that the allegation of incest was malicious slander.

69. *Hist.* 59.24.1. Cf. Barrett, *Caligula*, p. 37; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, p. 45.

70. *Ant.* 19.4.1-5; *War* 2.11.1-4. Cf. Dio, *Hist.* 60.8.2. Schwartz disputes the extent of Agrippa's role in Claudius's accession, and argues that the extension of his territories was not so much a reward for services rendered as expedient political restructuring of the eastern empire by Claudius; *Agrippa*, pp. 91-92.

71. *Ant.* 19.5.1; *War* 2.11.5. Schwartz argues that Agrippa received jurisdiction over the Temple in 37 CE, during the reign of Caligula, and appointed Simon Cantheras High Priest before the crisis (*Ant.* 19.6.2 §297); *Agrippa*, pp. 11-13. Schwartz's reconstruction depends on identifying Simon Cantheras with Simon the Just who, according to rabbinic tradition, received a simultaneous oracle announcing the death of Caligula (*t. Sot.* 13.6; *y. Sot.* 9.14; cf. also *Meg. Ta'an.* 22 Shebat). This took place in the Holy of Holies, and Simon must therefore have been in office as High Priest already. However, even if High Priest, Simon would have been in the Holy of Holies only on the Day of Atonement, and Caligula died on 24 January 41 CE; Schwartz's thesis, therefore, while not implausible, cannot be supported on the basis of Simon's oracle, which is incompatible with the known date of Caligula's death.

on Agrippa.⁷² Agrippa had early in his rise to power acquired a demeanour that antagonized less-favoured members of his family (Josephus, *Ant.* 18.7.1 §241), and the likelihood must be that his court and royal ideology subsequently developed along lines similar to those espoused by Caligula.⁷³ Agrippa was to die accepting from Gentiles acclamation as divine, which Jews would have regarded as idolatry.⁷⁴

The ambiguity of Agrippa's position, from a Jewish perspective, is therefore to be appreciated. He was a friend of Caligula, whom Jews would have regarded as an enemy, if not for his pretensions to divinity then at least for this intended desecration of the Temple. He was also seen to have been instrumental in ending the threat to the Temple, even if his motives were economic and political rather than pious,⁷⁵ and subsequently in securing the accession of Claudius, who was regarded as more benevolent towards the Jews. While head of a nominally Jewish dynasty, he was of Idumaeen ancestry, and was implicated in paganism and in particular emperor worship, and he violated Jewish aniconic sensibilities by minting coins with his image and that of Claudius.⁷⁶ This ambiguity in Agrippa had serious implications for Christians in Jewish Palestine during his reign, as will become clear in the discussion below.

5. *Agrippa and the Christians*

Acts 12.1-4 reports that the Christian community in Jerusalem suffered persecution during Agrippa's reign.⁷⁷ James the son of Zebedee was

72. Josephus, *Ant.* 19.5.1 §274; *War* 2.11.5 §215; Dio, *Hist.* 60.8.2-3. For discussion, see A.A. Barrett, 'Claudius, Gaius and the Client Kings', *CIQ* 40 (1990), pp. 284-86; E.M. Smallwood, 'High Priests and Politics in Roman Palestine', *JTS* 13 (1962), pp. 14-34 (16).

73. Schwartz, *Agrippa*, p. 133, 'hints of an imitation ruler cult'.

74. Acts 12.20-23; Josephus, *Ant.* 19.343-52. These accounts, while differing in detail, clearly allude to the same event. For the present purpose it is not necessary to establish which is closer to the historical reality. For discussion, see C.K. Barrett, *Acts* (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clark, 1994), pp. 588-92; H.G. Conzelmann, *Acts* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1987), p. 96; E. Haenchen, *Acts* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1971), p. 388; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 145-49; M.R. Strom, 'An Old Testament Background to Acts 12.20-23', *NTS* 32 (1986), pp. 289-92.

75. Josephus, *Ant.* 18.8.7-8 §§289-301; Philo, *Leg.* 35-42 §§261-332.

76. *Ant.* 19.7.1 §321, 8.3 §353, 9.1 §357. For discussion, see Grabbe, *Judaism*, pp. 433-44; Schürer, *History*, I, pp. 451-52; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 131-33.

77. While the family name Ἡρώδης is used, and not his proper name, it is

executed.⁷⁸ Peter was also arrested, presumably pending execution, but evidently evaded arrest or was released.⁷⁹ While it has been argued that this was the action of the Sanhedrin,⁸⁰ there seems no good reason to doubt the role of Agrippa. The allusion in Mk 13.9 to trials before kings may well allude to him, though not exclusively so.⁸¹ Neverthe-

nevertheless clear that the text refers to the actions of Agrippa I. Cf. Grabbe, *Judaism*, p. 430; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 39-40.

78. It is sometimes argued, on the basis of Mk 10.39-40, that John son of Zebedee was also killed at this time, but there is no hint of this in Acts; Conzelmann, *Acts*, p. 93. H. von Mendelssohn argues that Rev. 11.1-13 reflects the martyrdom of the two sons of Zebedee at the hands of Agrippa, who is also the beast of Rev. 13.1-8 who ruled by authority of a greater beast; *Jesus—Rebell oder Erlöser* (Hamburg: Hoffmann & Campe, 1981), pp. 224-26. This view is not widely supported in scholarship, even where allusions to this period are discerned in the text of Revelation. Cf. J.N. Birdsall, 'Irenaeus and the Number of the Beast', in *Festschrift J. Delobel* (Leuven: Peeters, forthcoming); K. Erbes, *Die Offenbarung des Johannis* (Gotha: Parthes, 1891), pp. 1-36; J.M. Ford, *Revelation* (New York: Doubleday, 1975), pp. 169-79, 210-30; F. Spitta, *Die Offenbarung des Johannis* (Halle: Waisenhaus, 1899), pp. 491-500; J.P.M. Sweet, *Revelation* (London: SCM Press, 1990), pp. 181-87, 206-13.

79. Acts 12.3-11. For discussion, see Barrett, *Acts*, pp. 569-77; Grabbe, *Judaism*, p. 433; Haenchen, *Acts*, p. 389; Pesch, *Apostelgeschichte*, p. 364; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 119-24. For discussion of the increasing persecution of the Judean Christians, see R. Jewett, 'The Agitators and the Galatian Congregation', *NTS* 17 (1971), pp. 198-212; B.I. Reicke, 'Judaean-Christianity and the Jewish Establishment, AD 33-66', in E. Bammel and C.F.D. Moule (eds.), *Jesus and the Politics of his Day* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984), pp. 145-52. Eusebius, *Chronicum*, and Jerome, *De Viris Illustribus* 5, date Peter's arrival in Antioch and Rome to 42 CE; cf. also *Kerygma Petrou*, cited by Clement, *Strom.* 6.5.43; Apollonius, cited by Eusebius, *H.E.* 5.18.14; *Acta Petri* 5. See Pesch, *Apostelgeschichte*, pp. 367-68. This is speculation based on Acts 12.17 and later Petrine traditions. It is unlikely that Peter went to Rome as early as this; cf. Conzelmann, *Acts*, p. 95; O. Cullmann, *Peter* (London: SCM Press, 1950), esp. pp. 77-123; Haenchen, *Acts*, pp. 385-86; Pesch, *Apostelgeschichte*, pp. 362, 369; G. Schneider, *Die Apostelgeschichte* (Freiburg: Herder, 1980), pp. 106-107. This is not to deny that the Caligula crisis and its aftermath were a major impetus to the spread of Christianity in the Mediterranean world; cf. N.H. Taylor, 'Caligula, the Church of Antioch, and the Gentile Mission', *Religion and Theology* 7 (2000), pp. 1-23.

80. J. Blinzler, 'Rechtsgeschichtliches zur Hinrichtung des Zebedaiden Jakobus (Apg xii 2)', *NovT* 5 (1962), pp. 191-206.

81. For detailed discussion, see N.H. Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity and the Caligula Crisis: II. The Markan Eschatological Discourse', *JSNT* 62 (1996), pp. 13-41. M. Hengel, *Studies in the Gospel of Mark* (London: SCM Press, 1985), p. 23,

less, Agrippa effected a more serious assault upon the Judaeans Christians than any previously experienced. Earlier judicial harassment by the Temple authorities (Acts 5.40) was surpassed in severity by the death of James and intended execution of Peter. Stephen had been perhaps a marginal figure, even within the Christian community, and died as a result of lynching by elements in a Hellenistic synagogue.⁸² James, on the other hand, was beheaded, an act of judicial execution perpetrated against a prominent member of Jesus' original group of disciples. As Galileans, James and Peter may have been marginal in Jerusalem society, but the persecution by Agrippa nonetheless represents an attack on the very core of the Christian community.

The judicial decapitation of James implies that he had been apprehended on a political charge.⁸³ This can be understood in terms of the social, economic and political context of Palestine in the aftermath of the Caligula crisis. The threatened desecration of the Temple had incited not only an agricultural strike but also mobilized wide-scale popular resistance in Judaea and Galilee.⁸⁴ Such movements would have been regarded as seditious by the Romans, and Agrippa would have been expected to ensure that they were dispersed and that normal economic activities were resumed and social stability restored.⁸⁵ Disruption of agriculture would have affected both the food supply and the tax revenue, which depended upon successful harvests. Food shortages

argues that this text refers to the emperor. The plural βασιλέων surely requires a more general application, and Hengel concedes that it may include Herodian kings, p. 133 n. 132.

82. Haenchen, *Acts*, pp. 295-96; Pesch, *Apostelgeschichte*, p. 126; Simon, *Stephen*; Taylor, 'Stephen'. Cf. S.G. Wilson, *The Gentiles and the Gentile Mission in Luke-Acts* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1973), p. 137.

83. *M. Sanh.* 9.1; cf. *Lk.* 9.9. For discussion, see S.G.F. Brandon, *Jesus and the Zealots* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1967), p. 97; R.J. Cassidy, *Society and Politics in the Acts of the Apostles* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1987), pp. 47-48, 97; J.D.M. Derrett, *Law in the New Testament* (London: Darton Longman & Todd, 1970), p. 340; Grabbe, *Judaism*, p. 433; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, p. 122. That μαχαίρα in Acts 12.2 alludes to Agrippa's exercise of the IUS GLADII would seem clear, cf. Barrett, *Acts* 575; pace, Blinzler, 'Rechtsgeschichtliches'.

84. Josephus, *War* 2.192; *Ant.* 18.263, 274; Philo, *Leg. Gai.* 225. For discussion, see Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity 1'; *idem*, 'Popular Opposition'.

85. For discussion, see Brandon, *Jesus*, pp. 85-99; Schwartz, *Agrippa*, pp. 119-23; J.W. Swain, 'Gamaliel's Speech and Caligula's Statue', *HTR* 37 (1944), pp. 341-49; Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity 1'.

and the inability to pay their taxes would have alienated many peasants from their land, and led to an upsurge in banditry, as, according to Josephus, the Herodian aristocracy had warned would be the case.⁸⁶

Against this background must be seen Agrippa's need to establish order and stability to the satisfaction of his Roman overlords, but without antagonizing his Jewish subjects. Swain has plausibly argued that movements such as those of Theudas and Tholomaeus, which were not suppressed until several years later by the Procurator Tiberius Julius Alexander, had their origins in the Caligula crisis, and that Agrippa was reluctant to take action against them.⁸⁷ In other words, rather than suppress the movements that had arisen during the preceding crisis, Agrippa sought a less popular scapegoat and accordingly attacked the church instead.

While Agrippa had, through his intervention with Caligula, been instrumental in defusing the crisis in Palestine, he nonetheless faced a crisis of credibility as a Jewish monarch. Not only did he inherit the ethnic and religious ambivalence of the Herodian family, but he had also been closely associated with Caligula. It had been through Caligula's patronage that Agrippa had risen to prominence and achieved power and position. He therefore needed in a sense to dissociate himself, however subtly and implicitly, from Caligula's hostility to the Jewish people and his scheme to desecrate the Temple, and to demonstrate his own credentials as a pious Jewish king and defender of Jewish national and religious institutions. To have pursued those who

86. *Ant.* 18.274. If Sabbath years were observed at this time, and, as has been argued, the year following the crisis was a Sabbath, the land would have been uncultivated for a second successive year, and the situation further exacerbated. See J. Jeremias, 'Sabbathjahr und neutestamentliche Chronologie', *ZNW* 27 (1928), pp. 98-103; Schürer, *History*, I, p. 447. Others argue that it was the year of the crisis itself, i.e. 40-41 CE, that was a sabbatical year; Grabbe, *Judaism*, p. 404; N. Hyldahl, 'Josefus som historieskriver', *DTT* 48 (1985), pp. 51-64; cf. Theissen, *Gospels*, p. 148.

87. Josephus, *Ant.* 20.1.1 §5, 5.1 §§97-98. Swain, 'Gamaliel's Speech', pp. 342-45. Swain regards Gamaliel's speech in Acts 5.34-39 as being misplaced, and belonging properly to the period of Agrippa I and the events of Acts 12.1-11. Cf. R.N. Gray, *Prophetic Figures in Late Second Temple Jewish Palestine* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), pp. 113-17, 133-43; Horsley and Hanson, *Bandits*, pp. 67, 164-67; McLaren, *Power*, pp. 105-106. Gray contends that, contrary to Josephus's account, Theudas and his followers were unarmed; *Prophetic Figures*, pp. 115-16.

had been mobilized in resistance to Caligula's scheme would have alienated Agrippa from his Jewish subjects, who were overwhelmingly loyal to the Temple, and to whom he needed to demonstrate his own loyalty to Judaism and to Jewish institutions.

Swain argues that the Christians in Jerusalem were the victims of Agrippa's political expediency. They had been isolated within Palestinian Judaism during the Caligula crisis, when their Christocentric eschatology had precluded participation in opposition to the threatened sacrilege, and consequently alienated them from the social groups from which they had previously derived their principal support.⁸⁸ There would have been minimal political repercussions for repressive measures against a marginalized community.⁸⁹ In persecuting a group that had not actively opposed the intended desecration of the Temple, Agrippa could demonstrate to the Palestinian Jews his loyalty to their religion and its central institution, and thus court popularity. The Christians were, furthermore, functioning openly in Jerusalem, unarmed and unconcealed, and would have been easier to apprehend than armed, or even unarmed, groups marauding around the countryside. In attacking the Christians, Agrippa could give the impression of taking effective measures against subversive elements, with a great deal less effort than would have been needed to apprehend Theudas or Tholomaeus, and without antagonizing the majority of his Jewish subjects.

Agrippa may have sought particularly to suppress movements with messianic overtones. According to Tertullian, the Herodians saw the Herods as messianic figures, and Epiphanius identifies Agrippa I in particular as having been the object of Herodian messianic hopes.⁹⁰

88. Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity 1'; *idem*, 'Jerusalem and the Temple in early Christian Life and Teaching', *Neot* 33 (1999), pp. 445-61.

89. Swain argues that Peter was released from prison because the measures had proved less popular with the populace than expected; 'Gamaliel's Speech', p. 345. Cf. Conzelmann, *Acts*, p. 93; G. Theissen, *The Sociology of Early Palestinian Christianity* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1978), p. 113. This, however, overlooks the degree of alienation and persecution to which the crisis had exposed the Palestinian Christians, cf. Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity 1'.

90. Tertullian, *De Praescriptione Haereticorum* 1; Epiphanius, *Panarion* 1.330. This view may be indirectly supported by the erection of a monument by Herod the Great on a site associated with the burial of David, Josephus, *Ant.* 16.182. For discussion, see B.W. Bacon, 'Pharisees and Herodians in Mark', *JBL* 39 (1920), pp. 102-11; A.J. Hultgren, *Jesus and his Adversaries* (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1979), pp. 154-57; Swain, 'Gamaliel's Speech', p. 344; Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity 1'.

This may be reflected in the allusion to false messiahs in Mk 13.21-22, if that text preserves a tradition that arose during the Caligula crisis and its aftermath.⁹¹ While it is most unlikely that Agrippa identified in any way with popular Jewish messianic and eschatological expectations, he was none the less eager to promote himself as a Jewish royal figure, and as one who had delivered Israel and the Temple from desecration by the Romans. Irrespective of whether Agrippa and his supporters actively appropriated messianic imagery, the Christians were presenting an alternative eschatological messianic vision, which constituted at the very least an implied challenge to Herodian aspirations. If James the brother of Jesus, rather than the son of Zebedee, was the intended victim of Agrippa's purge, this could indicate a perceived clash between the dynastic and possibly messianic aspirations of the Herodians and eschatological messianism of the primitive church in which the family of Jesus were coming into increasing prominence. Be this as it may, the messianism of the Christians would in itself have implied opposition to Agrippa's attempt to portray himself as the saviour of Israel.

6. Palestinian Christian Polemic against Agrippa

The persecution of the Palestinian Christians during the reign of Agrippa, I have suggested, lies behind the story of the temptation of Jesus on the mountain top in Mt. 4.8-10 // Lk. 4.5-8. The thrust of the polemic, I would argue, is that Agrippa, far from being the defender of the Jewish people and their Temple, was an idolater who not merely acquiesced in the civic cults of the Gentile cities in his territory, but had actively encouraged the self-apotheosis of Caligula and the accompanying prostration ceremonial. The Christians of Palestine had expected the erection in the Temple of Caligula's statue to be a catalyst for the establishment of the eschatological kingdom they awaited. The intervention of Agrippa, while delivering the Jews of Palestine from cataclysmic tragedy, would have been viewed by the Christians as having set back the parousia of Christ. Agrippa's persecution of the Christians, while undoubtedly intended to establish political stability and to gain credibility for the Herodian regime, was to the victims an act of usurpation against the true deliverer of the Jewish people, and of

91. Hengel, *Studies*, p. 23; Taylor, 'Palestinian Christianity 2'.

hostility to his followers. While Agrippa obtained his kingdom through subservience to Caligula, the personification of Satan, Jesus had refused to submit to Satan, and had rejected the reward of temporal power and kingship. Agrippa is the antitype of Jesus. Whereas Jesus was condemned by the Jewish hierarchy, executed by the Romans, and exalted by God, Agrippa was revered by the Jewish people, crowned by the Romans, and would be destroyed by God.

I have argued that the story of Jesus' temptations originated as a Palestinian Christian response to persecution under Agrippa I. Jesus, in isolation from human society, is challenged by Satan but repudiates incitement to idolatry and betrayal of God. The story is preserved and developed in diverse strands of the Gospel tradition, represented by Mark, Q and the *Gospel of the Hebrews*. The Q version is the most elaborate, having attracted further material and acquired through haggadic exegesis of Deuteronomy a new structure. Studies of the temptations in the wilderness and in the Temple, similar to that presented here on the temptation on the mountain top, would provide further and valuable insights into the life and experience of the early Palestinian church.

ABSTRACT

The story of Jesus' temptations in the wilderness originated as a Palestinian Christian response to persecution under Agrippa I during the aftermath of the Caligula crisis (c. 42 CE). Jesus, in isolation from human society, is challenged by Satan but repudiates incitement to idolatry and betrayal of God. In so doing he serves as an antitype to Agrippa, from the perspective of those whom he persecuted. The story is preserved and developed in diverse strands of the Gospel tradition, of which the most elaborate is the triple temptation story in Q.

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